THE PINK LEMON



Why Losing Isn't Always What It Looks Like

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CHAPTER ONE

Not One

I loved baseball before I knew much about winning or losing. I grew up in Cleveland in the 1990s, which was a good time to fall in love with the game. The Indians had players like Kenny Lofton, Albert Belle, and Omar Vizquel. They made the World Series twice that decade and lost both times. As a kid, I couldn't explain why being so close made it hurt more.

I watched games, played pickup ball with friends, and hit in batting cages. On library trips with my dad, I grabbed baseball books. *Nolan Ryan's Pitcher's Bible* is one I remember. I wanted to know why one person could throw harder and another could hit better. I just wanted to know how people got good.

My dad had a simple answer for what to do when you weren't good enough yet. You kept going. You didn't sit around feeling sorry for yourself. You figured out what to do and tried again, because nobody was going to climb inside your life and fix it for you. I still believe that.

Some losses really are that simple. You were not ready, or someone worked harder, or someone had a skill you did not. If that is what happened, I would rather know than have somebody protect my feelings with a story that isn't true.

Baseball taught me some of that. It also taught me that it wasn't the whole story. When I tried out for my high school team in eleventh grade, I felt ready, at least the kind of ready I understood then.

Then I got around other kids who wanted the same spot. Some had better gear. Some had travel teams, coaches, and practice that pickup games couldn't fully replace. That didn't mean they didn't work, because they did. It also didn't mean I had done nothing. We had reached the same tryout by different roads, and wanting a spot was not going to make my preparation equal to theirs.

I made the team. Then I got injured. I never really got to see what my full potential in baseball might have been. That's the story, and I don't need to make it bigger than it was. But I was disappointed. Baseball had filled so much of my imagination that I had to find new things to dream about.

I grieved it, and then I moved on. What I didn't understand yet was why this loss felt different. If another kid struck me out, that told me something. An injury didn't tell me anything like that. I had grown up learning that losing was evidence. You lose, so you practice more and figure out what the winner did that you didn't.

The injury ended the season without answering those questions. I had done enough to make the team, and I still didn't get the season I pictured. For a while, I acted like the second fact canceled the first.

As I've gotten older, I've noticed how fast we reach for an explanation. We say the winner worked harder and the loser didn't want it enough. Sometimes that's right. Often we're reading the ending backward. After someone succeeds, a morning routine or a book on the shelf becomes the reason, even when we don't know how much it mattered. We rarely look at the people who did the same things and still lost.

Years later, I was teaching, coaching, building businesses, raising sons, and losing things that cost a lot more than a baseball season. I kept coming back to one question: what does a loss actually prove? Sometimes it proves a lot, and sometimes it proves almost nothing.

When people care about you, they want to make your pain useful fast. They say, "Everything happens for a reason," or "Keep your head up." I get it. I have said those things too.

I am a Christian. I believe God can use things I would never have chosen. I also don't think my faith asks me to pretend I know why every painful thing happened. Some losses sent me in a new direction, and I can see that now because enough time has passed. But I don't think every bad thing is fertilizer and we just keep digging until we find the flower. Sometimes the only honest sentence is, *I hate that this happened.* I'm more okay with that now.

What worries me more is when we skip understanding the loss and jump straight to fixing ourselves. If somebody beat you because they were better, getting better makes sense. If the loss came down to something close to random, that needs a different talk. If something was taken from you, hunting for your own failure can turn into punishment. If you've been winning the wrong game, working harder can take you further from the life you want. If you walked away because staying cost too much, calling yourself a quitter may get the whole thing wrong.

Those are different losses. I didn't know that when I was seventeen. I knew one thing: get back up. I'm grateful my father taught me that, and it carried me through hard seasons. Learning when to keep moving, and where to aim that effort, took me much longer.

KEEP READING

That was one kind of loss. There are five.

The rest of *The Pink Lemon* sorts them out:

1. Somebody beat you
2. The margin was almost random
3. Something was taken
4. You were playing the wrong game
5. You walked out

Each one asks for a different response.

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